

HISTORICAL BRIEFING SHEET: OLD SPALDING COUNTY COURTHOUSE & JAIL

Location: 232 East Broad Street (Corner of E. Broad St. & S. 5th St.), Griffin, GA

Property Owner: Griffin Downtown Development Authority (DDA)

DDA Purchase Intent: Hotel Parcel Assembly and redevelopment of the Broad Street corridor.

National Register Status: Listed on the National Register of Historic Places (2000)

Historical Eras of Operation:

- **1860-1910:** First Spalding County Courthouse
- **1914-1984:** Spalding County Jail & Sheriff's Department

1. EXECUTIVE SUMMARY & SITE SIGNIFICANCE

Located just down the block from Heck Chapel, **232 East Broad Street** is one of the most remarkable surviving antebellum civic structures in Georgia. Built in 1860 as Spalding County's original seat of government, it served as the county's primary courthouse for half a century before undergoing a dramatic 1914 conversion into the county jail.

Architecturally, it is one of only **15 surviving antebellum courthouses in the state of Georgia** (out of 132 counties in 1860) and a rare example of **Italianate civic architecture** from that era. Its dual heritage as both a 19th-century judicial center and a 20th-century correctional facility gives it an extraordinary structural story for economic development, adaptive reuse, and historic preservation.

2. ARCHITECTURAL FEATURES & ORIGINS (1859-1860)

- **Design & Construction:** Designed by New York architect **Columbus Hughes** (who also designed Atlanta's old City Hall) and built by New Jersey builder **David Demarest** for a contract sum of \$12,000.
- **Architectural Style:** Built in the Italianate style, characterized by balanced proportions, pedimented facades, painted brick, and a rock foundation. (The original central clock/bell tower was removed during the 1914 conversion).
- **Local Connection:** Prior to moving west, a young **John Henry "Doc" Holliday** (born in Griffin in 1851) conducted legal and civic business inside this very courthouse before becoming a legendary Old West figure.

3. CHRONOLOGICAL HISTORY & CIVIC ERAS

ERA 1: THE FIRST COUNTY COURTHOUSE (1860-1910)

- **Civic Anchor:** Spalding County was carved out of Pike, Henry, and Fayette counties in 1851. Once completed in 1860, this building became the focal point of local government.
- **County Operations:** For over 50 years, all major legal and governmental decisions passed through these walls. Superior Court convened here, grand juries deliberated on the second floor, and deeds, taxes, marriage licenses, and probate wills were recorded downstairs.
- **Civil War Era:** The building survived the Civil War intact, witnessing the Union occupation of Griffin and the turmoil of Reconstruction.

ERA 2: TRANSFORMATION TO THE COUNTY JAIL (1914-1984)

- **The 1914 Overhaul:** After a new courthouse was constructed in 1911, the original building was retrofitted into the county jail in 1914.
- **State-of-the-Art Cells:** The renovation used cell blocks manufactured by the famed **Pauley Jail Works Company of St. Louis**. Newspapers at the time marveled at the design, calling it the "*most modern jail in the state.*"
- **Sheriff's Residence & Jail:** For 70 years, the facility housed inmates while also serving as the official residence for the county jailer/sheriff and their family. The interior retained isolation cells, male/female holding blocks, and historically included a trapdoor for judicial executions.
- **Film & Modern Use:** After the jail was decommissioned in 1984, the property served as county office space. In recent years, its well-preserved early 20th-century steel jail cells have made it a popular location for major film and TV productions (including *The Walking Dead*, *MacGyver*, and *Rectify*).

4. DDA CONTEXT FOR REDEVELOPMENT

- **Historic Tax Credits & Grants:** Because the building is listed on the National Register of Historic Places, redevelopment proposals are eligible for federal and state historic preservation tax credits, rural downtown development grants, and gap financing.
- **Structural Preservation:** The second-floor steel jailworks from Pauley Jail Works are an architectural highlight that can be integrated into adaptive reuse concepts (e.g., event spaces, creative office suites, micro-breweries, or cultural centers).